



ABRAHAM VERGHESE

Ryszard Kapuscinski in *The Emperor*. It is a much more beautiful place where the good-time girls of Addis drift in to the Hilton lounge, trailing perfume. And history gatecrashes into Missing, shattering the programmed lives of its inhabitants. It is the rebellion against the regime that allows Verghese to take the story to America. Still, the finest set pieces in this novel take place in an operation theatre; specifically, in the deep recesses of the human body. Verghese's pages smell of Dettol and carbolic acid. Medicine is not a metaphor here. In a conversation with INDIA TODAY, he says: "I wanted the whole novel to be of medicine, populated by people in medicine, the way Zola's novels are of Paris." Is it then the only world that sustains his creativity? "No," the novelist protests, "I think medicine itself is very creative both in the science and in the everyday practice. Patients present you with the ghost of a story and it is your job to take that fragment and imagine the rest from your repertoire of stories. Hence the term the art and science of medicine."

So how far has his own life story gone into the making of this novel? "The parts that resonate with my own life have to do with geography and history. There is a sense of loss when you leave your birthplace after so many years, even if it was not your land per se. So it turned out that the book portrays Ethiopia in the kind of detail and truth that allows people to see what an extraordinary country and people we are talking about." That said, his parents were not physicians; he did not grow up in a mission hospital; and he has no twin brother. "I suppose I wanted to pay tribute to the wonderful teachers I have had in surgery and in medicine, and to expose them to the pitfalls of medicine, the danger of losing yourself in the profession and not keeping a handle on your personal life, or as Yeats said, balancing 'perfection of the life with the perfection of work'." How does he himself achieve that perfection—the fine balance between the doctor and the writer? "I think there is no separation. My identity beyond that of being a father, husband, a son, a citizen and so on is completely that of being a physician, of having the privilege to serve not only patients but to serve the profession, to honour its ideals. So I see all writing, whatever form it takes, as being a function of that grand privilege of being a physician which in my case is everything." The art of the novel will be indebted to the grand privilege of this physician. ■

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